Purva Mimamsa/Purva Mimamsaka: one of the six mainstream Hindu ***darshanas***, this is systematic reflection upon the meaning and fruits of ritual religion prescribed by those portions of the eternal, authorless and infallible ***Vedas*** that are the only source of knowledge (***pramana***) about social and religious duty. They insist that the purpose of the ***Veda*** is to tell the qualified Hindu what actions have to be performed. The *Mimamsaka* outlook was not theistic in that they believed that the gods (*devas*) existed only in name, only in so far as their names were mentioned in the sacrificial rituals. They maintained that the universe is beginningless and that its continued existence depended upon the Vedic rituals and not upon divine creation and support. The cosmos is a self-regulating process, the arena in which sentient beings perform actions and reap their consequences.

Exact performance being necessary for the ritual's success, precise understanding of the instructions was essential. This lead to a concern with the nature and operation of words and sentences. They claim that the relation between a word and its object is innate (*autpattika*) and permanent (***nitya***). The word–meaning relation holds between the word's sound and the form (***akriti***) common to the class of objects that it denotes. Word sounds participate in the nature of their objects.

The need to establish the infallible authority of the ***Veda*** led them into enquiries into the scope of the means of knowledge (***pramana***). *Mimamsakas* say that the mind is a blank slate, passively receiving data. Cognitions are acts that manifest a mind-independent external world. As such, they may be presumed always valid. So the authority of the *Vedic* commands is unquestionable simply because they are known.

The basic text is the *Mimamsa Sutra* of *Jaimini* (c. 100 CE) with the commentary by *Shabara* (fourth century CE).